

THE "BIG" FISHERMEN OF LAKE CHILWA: A PRELIMINARY SURVEY OF ENTREPRENEURS IN A RURAL ECONOMY

Pauline E. Phipps
Lake Chilwa Research Project
University of Malawi

This article is based on the analysis of a sample survey of Lake Chilwa carried out between September and November 1970 by Dr. A. B. Chilivumbo the author. Several areas around the lake were specifically selected and a schedule was administered by three research assistants. Fishermen were interviewed as they were met, resulting in 411 completed schedules.

The study of the fishermen of Lake Chilwa forms part of the ongoing Lake Research Project set up in 1966 under the directorship of M. D. Chiswick, Professor of Biology at Chancellor College, University of Malawi, to study aspects of Lake Chilwa and its environs (Kalk 1970). The project research has concentrated on such aspects as the biology of the lake, the hydrology of the lake basin, and an ecological study of the northwest plain. A study of fish catch has been reported on (Williams 1969) as well as initial studies on the ecology of fishing (Chipeta 1968).

Lake Chilwa, approximately twenty-four miles long and seventeen miles wide, is a shallow, saline lake of an average depth of seven feet. It has no outlet and is surrounded by swamps and reed beds which are especially extensive in the north. The lake is that it has been subject to considerable annual fluctuations in water levels. Seasonal changes are about three feet above or below the average rainfall and evaporation, but since 1949 the level has fluctuated to practically nothing in October 1968. This last recession of the lake to a few muddy pools and the whole area to a ghost of its former self.

When water levels are high, Lake Chilwa has a very high production of fish. The main species predominate and are important commercially: Tilapia shirana, a bream type; Clarias mossambicus (Peters) (mamba), catfish and Barbus paludinosus (Peters) (mamba), a small shoaling fish.

The population on Lake Chilwa is a shifting one. There are few permanent villages on the shoreline; most are situated on the Chilwa plain so that most fishermen

Data has been collected since the early 1960's: 1963, 3,600; 1968, 100 (not up); 1969; 3,200; 1970, 4,600; 1971, 4,000 short tons.